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### Terror is not just blasts. It is also the fear created in the minds of young Muslims by the state.

**H**ave a blast!" This was slang used by youngsters years ago to wish their friends who were heading for a party. Now hearts stop when one hears of a blast.

Years ago, Muslims and Islam in India were not on the "top of the mind" of the people, especially non-Muslims. My childhood memories take me back to the time when there were "mild communal riots" in some parts of Bangalore. But they died down as fast as they had started. Sadly today, "terror" is a term used loosely to define Muslims. Terror is not just blasts. It is also the fear created in the hearts and minds of Muslims by the men in khaki, the state and hordes of right-wing groups. You have a mainstream paper flashing the news on their front page: "Three jihadis picked up from HAL". Slamming a community as "terrorists" is entirely unjustified. Do you think any innocent Muslim will get a job in an MNC after all the blasphemous reports going around about Muslims? I think powerful elements in the state apparatus and some groups in India want to scare the Muslims so much that they flee the country!

India is not a target of "Islamic terrorism". According to me, anything that goes against law is terrorism. Corruption by politicians is terrorism, poaching is terrorism. Caste killings are terrorism. Let's talk about this rather than harping about 'Islamic terrorism'. There are millions of Muslims who are working in India, contributing in their own way to the economy and culturalscape of this country. If you try to alienate them, it can only have ominous consequences for the struggle for true democracy in the country.

I have faith in God Almighty that He will set things straight for India. I was born here, I want the best things to happen for this country. I still do not fear being a Muslim in India.



MANEESH AGNIHOTRI



## MUFTI MOHAMMED ISMAIL QAZMI

Malegaon-based cleric who heads a  
political party, Teesra Mahaz

### Muslims also need to introspect why they are always held responsible for anti- national activities

**T**oday, it is not just the average Muslim in India but the community across the world that feels victimised for being referred to as the "terrorist". Peace still eludes us and there is still an air of dissatisfaction. Since we have seen our elders being happy when immersed in religious activities, people have started realising that religion might be the only way to attain this peace.

All over India, there are two types of problems. When there are blasts and the real evidence is presented before the courts of law, the court does not accept it as true and people are let off (read VHP activists being let off after the Nanded blasts in 2006). There are several examples where courts have acquitted people despite concrete evidence against them. Earlier when there was a blast, it was always perpetrated by someone from "outside the country". Now whenever anything happens, a Muslim from within the country is always held responsible. Due to such allegations, Muslims feel targeted. On both